So four men standing there in their suits, with me still dripping sweat in my United uniform: it felt like we were all waiting to find out what was going to happen next. The manager said I should sit down and listen. What I heard I had trouble believing. I was trying to make some sense of what was being said. *This can't be happening. This shouldn't be happening.*

I looked across at Victoria and I could see in her eyes she already had the same question in her mind as I did. *What are we going to do?*

After a tip-off from the *News of the World*, four men and a woman had been arrested in London. They were part of a gang of art thieves—four more people were picked up that night and the following morning—believed to be planning to kidnap Victoria, Brooklyn and Romeo and hold them for a £5 million ransom.

Victoria had already heard all this and she was doing her best to be strong about it. She'd jokingly said if they were going to kidnap her, they'd have to kidnap her hairdresser as well. Now, she was listening to the details again, and watching me take it all in. And I was really upset. I felt my stomach turn over: it's anybody's worst kind of nightmare, although not many people will have to listen to policemen talking them through a threat that's very real indeed. Right at the start, the guys from Scotland Yard were telling us that they took this thing seriously. They'd already made those arrests and, as of right now, they were putting officers outside the houses at Alderley Edge and Sawbridgeworth.

Sure enough, by the time we got home, there was a police car at the end of the lane and a couple of policemen were on duty at the gate. We went in and there was another car in the drive, right outside our front door. I think Victoria and I were trying hard not to panic and, I've got to say, it helped that the police seemed so in control of things so quickly. That evening and the next morning, as we read the papers and watched the television coverage of it all, the truth of what might have happened started to hit home. We might have been used to seeing and hearing stories about ourselves, often to do with things we've had no idea about beforehand, but this was different. There were the pictures of the gang at the gates of the house down south and details of the threats they'd made about what might happen to Victoria if I didn't pay up: that kind of wickedness and on my own doorstep made my blood run cold. I think it was overnight that the shock really sank in for both of us.

We were upset and scared, but you can't just hide and hope it will all go away. My family's safety is the most important thing in the world; it's the